

Media construction of Britain as a destination for Japanese tourists: Social constructionism and tourism

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ABSTRACT

KEYWORDS: *tourism research methods, social constructionism, media-induced tourism, representations, destination images, Japanese tourism*

Media-induced tourism, which involves visits to places associated with films, television programmes and literature, has become a growing phenomenon yet has been little studied empirically. This paper delineates the empirical study to investigate the phenomenon highlighting the theoretical position and research methodology for this specific research project. This paper, specifically, outlines a social construction theory that provides an approach that locates tourism in a wider context of society and culture of a generating country and views contemporary tourism as a social and cultural phenomenon.

INTRODUCTION

Tourism has now become a global social and cultural practice as millions of people

in the world today move from place to place, increasingly beyond the borders of their own nations, to participate in tourist experiences at global tourism destinations. It is well recognised that through a huge variety of media, people receive information about tourist destinations, gain knowledge about these areas and construct their images, which form the basis of their destination choices (Gunn, 1972; Butler, 1990; Stabler, 1990; Echtner and Ritchie, 1991).

While promotional efforts of a destination through media such as advertising, travel brochures and travel guidebooks play an important role in influencing the tourist decision-making process, there are many other non-touristic-directed information sources which could play an important part in the reason for travel, such as news reports and popular culture. Watching television and videos, going to the cinema and reading are also widespread forms of leisure activity in the modern world. Those popular cultural forms of the media are enjoyed and used by masses of people as a source of joy, pleasure, daydreaming and fantasy as well as understanding of the world in everyday life (Carey, 1988). With the tremendous discursive and economic powers of global media corporations such as the Sony Corporation and the Disney Corporation, the mass media, both locally and

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globally, increasingly extend their sphere of influence by providing representations, images and discourses of the world to global audiences.

For example, there has been a growing worldwide phenomenon that tourists visit a destination or attraction as a result of the place being featured or portrayed in the popular cultural forms of the media which are not directly concerned with tourism promotion or marketing, such as films, television dramas and novels. This phenomenon has created a new form of cultural tourism — 'movie-induced tourism' (Riley *et al.*, 1998) or 'media-related tourism' which involves visits to places celebrated for associations with books, authors, television programmes and films' (Busby and Klug, 2001: 316). Films, television and literature can influence the travel preferences and destination choices of those who engage in these leisure activities by exposing the attributes and attractions of destinations and creating favourable destination images through their representations (Butler, 1990; Iwashita, 1999; Busby and Klug, 2001). Furthermore, the tourism industry increasingly makes use of images which are drawn from popular culture associated with places to promote tourist destinations. In other words, as publicity and promotional media for attracting tourists the popular cultural forms of the media have become a catalyst for tourism in contemporary globalised media-saturated society. This is an area deserving a great deal more attention, but despite this recognition, there has been little empirical investigation of the phenomenon.

The study discussed here, therefore, explores this phenomenon through empirical research to investigate *how* and *to what extent* popular cultural forms of the media (those not directly associated with tourism and destination marketing but featuring a particular place) have an effect on international tourism, and to identify what roles

they play in influencing overseas tourists' behaviour, in terms of their travel destination choices and places to visit within the chosen destination. This study focuses on the media's power to generate awareness and create images, perceptions and representations of places and their inhabitants, through a case study of Japanese tourism to Britain. The topic of this research project is the impact of the media as popular culture on international tourism: the media construction of Britain as a tourist destination for Japanese tourists. This paper, specifically, highlights the theoretical position and research methodology for this research project.

THEORETICAL APPROACH TO THIS RESEARCH

Tourism is a complex, ever-changing human activity which arises in part from personal, internal needs or wants and in part from external social, economic, cultural influences on people. There are a number of theories and approaches applied to tourism research which provide an interpretative basis for understanding the multi-dimensional phenomenon of tourism. This study draws upon concepts from various social sciences including sociology, geography, psychology, marketing, cultural studies and leisure studies. In particular, this research project approaches tourism from a perspective derived largely from a *social constructionism* viewpoint to understand and explain tourism as a global social and cultural phenomenon.

The theory of social construction

It is beyond the scope of this paper to discuss what social constructionism is in detail, so only a brief overview of its basic aspects will be given and then the way in which social constructionist ideas can be applied to tourism studies will be briefly discussed.

The phrase 'social construction' or 'con-

struction' appears often and increasingly in titles of scholarly writings of human sciences including tourism studies. Gergen (1998) suggests that social constructionism has given voice to a wide range of new topics and has played an important role in a variety of newly developing areas of study such as cultural studies and media studies. There are various social constructionist approaches, including symbolic interactionism, ethnomethodology, phenomenology and structuralism although for many sociologists social constructionism has its roots in the phenomenology of Berger and Luckmann's (1971) 'The Social Construction of Reality'.

It may be impossible to find any single characteristic that these different approaches hold in common, but generally, social constructionism refers to the principle that social and cultural phenomena and individuals are social constructions produced and reproduced through historically and culturally situated interactions of people and human activities in society. Objects are not given in the world but constructed, negotiated, formed and fashioned by human beings through their social interaction and practices. Similarly, a great deal of people's experience and sense of various realities, and the social world in which they live, are to be conceived of as socially constructed. Identities that were thought to be given naturally are also socially and culturally created, maintained, modified or even recreated, whether as individual, group, place, landscape or nation-state, through human activities.

People know and understand the social world and human societies as a result of the meanings they give to its different parts and phenomena. All construction of 'reality' thus must be seen as a product of the human capacity for thought, and is subject to change and variability. The social product and its meaning is not fixed but always in a process and they therefore

change over time and in different cultures or societies. Social constructionists respect the individual meaning in people's everyday lives (the centrality of everyday activities). Giddens (1984) argues that all human beings are knowledgeable agents who know a great deal about the situations or conditions and consequences of what they do in their everyday lives and have the inherent capacity to change social circumstances, have reasons for their actions, make choices and act on their own behalf.

Social constructionists stress the importance of language as the primary means of social constructions of the social world, human activities and individuals because language is not only the medium in which meanings, descriptions or characterisations of things are configured but also the medium of communication between people. For social constructionists, language and discourses, variously theorised, are the dominant carriers of categories and meanings as well as the media which provide much of the raw material for human activities. In other words, social reality is socially constructed by people through language and discourse.

APPLICATION OF THE THEORY TO TOURISM

Social construction of human beings as the subject of tourism practices

Social constructionists hold the view that human beings are born into a particular society or a given social world with a certain social structure that pre-exists and they are socialised in such a way that they will be able to function in that social structure and develop their personal identities. Individuals are taught all-important knowledge and skills including the rules, roles, rights, duties, norms and values of the given society and culture through a continuous process of socialisation. Socialisation is provided formally through institutions such as

the family and the school system, and informally through friends or peer groups and the mass media including television, films and books. In the process of socialisation, people develop perceptions, appreciations, thoughts, namely ways of thinking, all of which provide action frames. Since the socialisation process reflects social conditions and social structures into which individuals are born, people are socialised differently and limited by the material, social and cultural resources that they can use for their actions. Human beings are enabled and constrained by the social structure within which they act. Thus, society, social structures and socialisation processes have profound effects on shaping human beings and their behaviour including tourism practice. In contemporary information society especially, the mass media as one of the socialisation agencies, have played an important role in distributing information about tourism as one of the more positive ways of enjoying life.

Social construction of the meaning of tourism practices

People's attitudes towards tourism and leisure in general, eg whether they regard the practices as of little importance, or of great importance, and the meaning of tourism practices change over time in the different social and cultural contexts in which tourism occurs. For example, in the period of early capitalism, many people perceived tourism practices as a means of giving simple pleasure or fun by being away from the place where they worked and away from the boring and monotonous pain of industrial production. In this period of modern late-capitalism when society has shifted towards a consumer society dominated by objects and signs, people's desires and needs to consume products and services are socially constructed. Tourism experiences are thus increasingly commodified and transformed into images of themselves

for consumption (Britton, 1991). Thus, people have been socialised to think of tourism practices in terms of products to be consumed, increasingly with the intangible aesthetic qualities that they offer, such as images, signs and symbols. Furthermore, for many people living in a world of permanent change or in a globalised society, 'mobility', referring to the freedom to move and to choose where to be, has become the most important value (Bauman, 1998). An access to tourism has become an essential part of people's everyday lives and part of what it is to be a contemporary global citizen (Bauman, 1998; Urry, 2000).

Social construction of tourism practices: motivations

It is a general assumption that tourism is a form of escape from the home environment, based on the experience of contrast between the ordinary and everyday life (the familiar) and the faraway and extraordinary (Urry, 1990; Rojek, 1993). Tourism is a marginal activity which involves touristic deviation or a break from the routines, obligations and monotony of modern everyday life. Ryan (2000) also suggests that tourists are in search of new or different experiences from those normally encountered in everyday life. Similarly, Gottlieb (1982) suggests that tourists seek to include inversion of the everyday in their holiday experiences, and tourism practice is a means to remove them physically and socially from their native social system, the social structure of society. Rojek (1997) also argues that it is the cultural difference (even if it is artificially constructed) between people's everyday practices (routines) and practices at tourist sites that impels people to travel, because the cultural difference or contrast is an immediate source of pleasure and curiosity. Likewise, Squire (1994) suggests that through tourism practices people are able

to indulge in dreams and idylls which are not usually part of their ordinary life. Thus, travel desires and motivations have been constructed largely by society or socio-cultural contexts and shaped by people's everyday lives.

Many authors (eg Urry, 1995; Crouch, 1999) argue that people's social identities are increasingly constructed not through work, but through their consumption of certain goods, services and signs including tourism consumption. Tourism (what people do and where they go on holiday) can be seen as an expression of people's identity (who they are and who they want to be) because tourism practice is now a sign that signifies the ability to consume certain tourism products and can be used to reinforce distinctions (status or prestige) between different social and cultural groups. Tourism also provides a reference point for identities through the encounter of customs, habits and values which differ from the tourists' own.

Although there are many different conceptions of tourism motivation, the perspective of social constructionism suggests that tourism practice can be understood as social or cultural, infused with subjective meaning and the intention of the social actor within the cultural frame of the person's everyday life, including prior knowledge, expectations, fantasies and mythologies created in the tourist's origin culture. In other words, tourism practice should be analysed within the theory of social action, the motivation of which is derived from the social and cultural context of everyday life (McCabe, 2001).

Social construction of tourist destinations

The perspective of social constructionism suggests that there is nothing 'natural' about tourism destinations because they are socially and culturally constructed by human intervention to be tourist oriented.

Although destinations with extraordinary natural qualities can easily achieve the status of popular tourist destinations, any destinations can be intentionally shaped by people and society to carry meanings, values and images, which are special and significant to tourists. People can transform places and landscapes into tourist destinations both physically or materially and perceptually or symbolically by giving meanings and values. Tourist destinations are therefore no longer defined in terms of geographical and physical attributes alone (Lefebvre, 1991).

Places, spaces and landscapes can acquire identities for tourists through various forms of representations; how they are represented. Hughes (1998) argues that much tourism depends on the qualities of a destination as represented to tourists through tourism promotional materials such as guidebooks, brochures, travel writing and travel television programmes. Dann (1996) suggests that the language of tourism used in travel brochures, travelogues, advertising and word-of-mouth, contains norms, values, prescriptions and proscriptions, namely cultural messages. The tourism industry increasingly constructs discourses about tourism practice, tourist sites and destinations by offering a particular way of seeing them. It is language and discourse which describe tourist destinations and inform the tourists what must be seen before the trip is undertaken. Tourism has been framed by the particular way of seeing that is the product of social construction (Hughes, 1992). Places and landscapes may have no meanings in nature but meanings are constructed through language and discourses, and attributed to the destination. Thus, ordinary places and landscapes can be transformed into tourist attractions and destinations through the sociolinguistic system (Dann, 1996).

As noted above, place representations through the media including films, televi-

sion programmes and novels, which are not directly concerned with tourism promotion, can have cumulative effects on people by creating certain images, expectations and beliefs of what places and their residents are like. In other words, media representations of places entail the construction of an imagined geography of the place and its identity. People tend to be motivated to visit a particular place by specific images, memories, associations, emotional commitment or attachment to the place and meanings (Schama, 1996), all of which are created through their participation in those cultural forms of the media.

It should be noted, however, that a destination as a social construction can be perceived and interpreted differently by different groups of people and individuals because social and cultural meanings are subjective and differ between individuals (MacCannell, 1976). Tourist destinations can be viewed as cultural texts that are read and interpreted in different ways (Squire, 1998). In other words, tourists themselves generate countless cultural meanings about tourist destinations. Ringer (1998) suggests that recognition of the socially constructed destination helps to clarify subjective emotional attachments held by both its residents and visitors to specific locations and places. On the other hand, Massey and Jess (1995) argue that these interpretations of place are not the product of individual feelings and experiences alone, but are manifestations of the wider power relations which structure people's lives. Tourism destinations can therefore be constructed, contested, disrupted and transformed as a result of competition and changes in the power relations as well as changing patterns of consumption and production. Squire (1998: 82–3) argues that 'tourist destinations are not merely a leit-motif for geographic place; rather they are social and cultural constructions whose meanings and values are negotiated and

redefined by diverse people, and mediated by factors often related only tangentially to a particular tourist setting'.

Limitations of the social constructionist approach to tourism

As noted above, the perspective of social constructionism can provide important insights into tourism phenomenon. Cohen (1999), however, points out that there are limits to social constructionism because any tourist object, site or sight can not only have aspects or elements which are socially and culturally constructed, but also those which are established as uncontestable 'hard facts' or 'essence'. That is, destinations can change the ways in which they are visually and verbally presented, but their physical features and natural resources cannot be easily changed by social and cultural forces. Natural resources endowed on destinations such as sandy beaches, waterfalls, mountains and climate are the primary attractions which can stimulate tourist interest without any cultural or social elements.

Similarly, in terms of motivation and behaviour of the tourist, people can be motivated to travel by their unique biological and psychological impulses which are separated from the outer social world and are unlikely to change. Layder (1994) argues that the psychobiography that people have in their heads is an underlying mechanism that generates action, response and reaction to their social circumstances. The human mechanism is innate, rather than a reflection of the social condition.

It is true that human activity including tourism practices is dynamic, reflecting a mixture of internal (biological and psychological) and external (sociological including cultural, economic and political) influences. Biological and psychological impulses, however, are partly intertwined with social and cultural conditions, which increasingly help in shaping a modern individual's con-

sciousness, perception, and meanings of, and attitude towards tourism and tourist destinations (Wang, 2000). There is little doubt that many tourism practices in modern times can be explained by social and cultural factors and they cannot be explained solely by people's internal factors. Why tourism is what it is today can be understood in relation to the society and culture surrounding individuals. The appeal of a tourist destination also lies largely in the degree of attractiveness of the socio-cultural environment, which can be used imaginatively to differentiate the destination from other destinations with similar physical environments. Despite the limitations of the perspective, it is therefore worthwhile studying tourism in terms of the wider social and cultural contexts in a changing contemporary world which can affect people's psyches, minds and feelings.

It is clear, however, that the social constructionist approach needs new directions in order to analyse contemporary tourism practices. Urry (2000) argues that it is increasingly non-human agencies or objects that reconstitute social relations and social structures in contemporary globalised society. There is no such thing as an uniquely 'human' society because almost all societies involve networks of connections between humans and non-human elements such as machines, technologies, objects, texts, images and physical environments (nature) (Urry, 2000). He therefore suggests that it would be more helpful to draw attention to the complex intersecting relationships of humans with diverse non-human objects.

Urry (2000) further argues that the development of various global networks and global flows of information, capital, images, people and cultures undermine societies with structures which have been understood to possess the powers to produce and reproduce themselves. As noted above, people living in a globalised society

are now able to consume products, ideas and services from many different nations and cultures and the daily lives of people are not free from those influences. Urry (2000: 32) therefore argues 'behaviour and motivation are less societally produced and reproduced but are the effect of a more globally organised culture that increasingly breaks free from each and every society'. It is necessary, therefore, to study and consider tourism within the context of globalisation, focusing on the globalised culture and its implication for tourism.

RESEARCH METHODS

Since any social constructions are particular to specific social worlds or cultures, it was thought that a case study bounded in time and place aiming at gaining an in-depth picture of the case would be the most suitable method to employ. The study discussed here, therefore, involves a case study of Japanese international tourism to Britain by which to investigate the effects of the media as popular culture on international tourism. It is a fact that the two countries provide examples of postmodern-globalised societies and the development of international tourism in both countries (Britain as a receiving country with a wide range of media-induced attractions and Japan as a generating country) that is significant. The main question of this study is what roles do popular cultural forms of the media (featuring Britain but not directly associated with tourism destination marketing) play in shaping Japanese tourists' behaviour, in terms of their choice of Britain as a destination and of places to visit within Britain? The relationship between the images of Britain shaped by the promotional media, those constructed in popular culture, and the actual perceived images of Britain held by Japanese tourists who have a strong interest in Britain as a tourist destination, will be explored.

This research project is currently being

undertaken and the survey with a combination of a questionnaire survey and face-to-face individual interviews has already been carried out. In order to identify perceived images of Britain (both the overall image of Britain as a nation or a national entity and the specific image of Britain as a tourist destination) held by Japanese tourists, and what films, television programmes and novels play a significant role in increasing interest in Britain, an internet-based questionnaire survey of a sample of 323 Japanese members of the Britain Travel Club was carried out for two months early in 2002 in Japan. Britain Travel Club is an internet-based club with its own website, organised by the British Tourist Authority Japan Office and it has a membership of approximately 7,000 as of 20th June, 2002. The majority of club members have a common interest in Britain as a tourist destination and have visited Britain before. Thirty respondents who answered that their interest in Britain had been inspired by the media as popular culture, were then chosen for qualitative interviews. The interviews were conducted in Japan in June 2002 to generate more information on the perceived images of Britain, how and why respondents chose or choose Britain and what roles the media play in influencing their actual travel choice behaviour (where tourists actually go). A combination of quantitative (descriptive) content analysis and semiotic analysis of the British Tourist Authority's promotional materials (including their website) is being undertaken in order to identify the projected images of Britain as a tourist destination in the Japanese market. Semiotic analysis and discourse analysis will be conducted to explore the ways in which Britain is constructed and represented in various popular cultural forms of the media, focusing on films, television programmes and literature to which Japanese residents have been exposed. This will enable the identification

of the popular images created through media representations of Britain.

CONCLUSION

Social construction theory provides not only a theoretical framework for this specific research project but also helps the researcher to decide the research design and methods as well as the focus points for the investigation of the media-induced tourism phenomenon. It draws the researcher's attention to the 'subjective', socio-cultural and symbolic nature of tourist destinations and to mediating influences, in particular the mass media. Social construction theory recognises the legitimacy of everyday experiences, where the meanings and values of many things are constructed and clarifies the importance of the media, in particular popular culture, as artefacts which humans create in everyday life.

Social construction theory is an approach that does not isolate tourism from the wider context of society and culture, and the social and cultural changes which occur. It demonstrates that tourism cannot be understood as a social and cultural phenomenon without reference to the social and cultural contexts within which it is produced. The recognition that tourists, tourism practices and tourist destinations are social constructions which are produced and reproduced by ongoing processes, in particular the globalisation processes, and can change over time and in different social and cultural contexts, provides a better understanding of contemporary tourism.

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